had bought a 9.9 per cent stake in Jio in early 2020. As had Google, which took a 7.7 per cent stake. ‘The fabulous thing Jio did,’ he concluded, ‘was to bring 400–450 million online with access to affordable mobile broadband, followed by Vodafone and Airtel.’ Speaking of a new effort to bring millions of small retailers online, he explained that ‘a lot of the effort we are doing now addresses the other side of it, now that we have 500 million plus people online’.[24] The fact of Indians going online on their phones was reshaping consumer businesses, making older models of media outreach obsolete. The same logic applied to politics too.

BJP Dominates Political Advertising on Facebook and Google

One way to understand how political parties approached this digital shift is to track the money they claimed to spend on online advertising. The BJP outstrips the rest in its declared spending on advertising in the digital domain. Ahead of the 2019 general elections, Google and Facebook began Ads Transparency initiatives in India. This meant that, for the first time, these two Big Tech companies began reporting the exact number of declared political advertisements they received, the entities involved and the amounts spent. Between February and May 2019, they declared cumulative political online advertising of ₹58.67 crore. The money spent on both platforms was similar, though Facebook’s ad library received a far higher volume of individual advertisements. Google declared 12,276 political advertisements worth ₹29.3 crore. Facebook, in its India Ad Library, declared a total of 1,32,419 advertisements worth ₹29.28 crore.[25]

The BJP dominated digital political spending on both Google and Facebook in this period. On Google, it accounted for 41.4 per cent (₹12.19 crore) of political advertising. Tamil Nadu’s DMK scored a distant second with 13.6 per cent (₹4 crore) and the Congress was third with 10 per cent (₹3 crore). On Facebook, the BJP accounted for 14.7 per cent (₹4.3 crore) of political advertising, and the Congress came in a distant second with 6.1 per cent (₹1.8 crore).

Overall, this trend in electoral spending mirrors offline trends on party earnings. It is not an outlier. In 2017-18, the BJP declared a